

Joshua Aarons

Doctoral Candidate — Economics Department — University of California San Diego

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Contact Information

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Education

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics
University of California San Diego

Expected completion: June 2027

B.A. in Economics
Carleton College

2016

Fields

Environmental Economics, Labor Economics, and Public Economics

References

Judson Boomhower (Chair)	Mark Jacobsen	Joshua Graff Zivin	Itzik Fadlon
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Job Market Paper

“What’s Driving High Electric Vehicle Fast Charging Prices?”

Fast charging stations are considered crucial to hastening electric vehicle adoption, but due to a lack of data, there has been little work on competition or consumer behavior. I compile novel datasets on charging station prices and charging quantities to measure how consumers and competing stations respond to new stations entering the market. I show that the fast charging market is characterized by high markups, but it is not obvious whether these reflect high fixed costs or firms’ price-setting power. I implement a difference in differences model to measure the impacts of station entry and find no effect of market entry on competitor charging volumes or prices. Given the lack of price competition, I investigate how firms choose prices. I estimate a model of consumer demand for fast charging to recover own- and cross-price elasticities of demand. I use these elasticities to show that charging networks’ prices are consistent with maximizing charging market profits with linear prices, which leads to higher prices and greater deadweight loss than two-part tariffs. Observed prices are higher than the prices that would most efficiently recover fixed costs, suggesting there is room for networks to lower prices.

Working Papers

- “Takeoffs and Test Scores: The Impact of Noise Pollution on Standardized Test Performance”

Noise pollution is ubiquitous in urban life. While noise exposure diminishes health and productivity, less is known about its impacts on learning outcomes. I estimate the causal effect of noise pollution on standardized test performance by isolating exogenous variation in aircraft noise pollution and implementing a value-added model to control for student ability. I find a large negative impact on math scores. Moving from a school at the 25th percentile of exposure to one at the 75th is associated with a 0.1 standard deviation decrease in math test scores, twice as large as the impact of missing 10 school days.

Relevant Positions Held

Graduate Student Researcher, Judson Boomhower 2022-2025

- Compiled insurance rates and hurricane risk by scraping insurance and categorical risk model filings
- Conducted analyses of insurer's pricing of wildfire and hurricane risk
- Aggregated and cleaned oil and gas well records to build panels of well ownership and production

Health Policy Center, Urban Institute 2017-2021

Research Analyst 2019-2021

Research Assistant 2017-2019

- Used Medicare administrative data to compare home health and post-acute care use patterns across different Medicare insurance plan characteristics
- Assessed determinants of access to mental health and substance use disorder care
- Derived propensity score and entropy balance weights for an evaluation of care models for Medicare and Medicaid beneficiaries
- Provided descriptive analysis of differences across populations in outcomes such as access to health insurance, mental health care, and exposure to COVID-19

Fellowships, Honors, and Awards

Benjamin C. Horne Memorial Prize, UC San Diego Department of Economics 2025

Clive Granger Research Fellowship, UC San Diego Department of Economics 2025

Summer Graduate Teaching Scholar – Outstanding Scholar Award, UC San Diego 2025

Teaching Assistant Excellence Award, UC San Diego Department of Economics 2025

Presentations

Annual Conference, Western Economic Association International 2026

SustainableED Conference, Annenberg Institute at Brown University 2026

AERE Summer Conference, Association of Environmental and Resource Economists 2024

Other Information

Citizenship: United States

Skills: R, Python, Stata